THE FLAG-BEARERS
(Clockwise from left) Leeza Mangaldas, Dr Tanaya Narendra and Neha Bhat



forefront, or the growing popularity of content creators on social media who are demystifying sex and sexuality—it's clear that India is gradually warming up to a sexual awakening.

"We have long been conditioned to feel a lot of shame around sex. To a large extent, there's still the overarching Victorian morality that dictates that the only truly acceptable or legitimate context within which sex can be had is within a heterosexual endogamous marriage, with the intent to have children," says Leeza Mangaldas, who started her journey as a sexuality educator seven years ago.

"I am glad I have been able to play a part in the collective endeavour to make these conversations feel normal and to imagine a world where all sexual experiences are consensual, safe, and pleasurable," says the bestselling author and founder of personal care brand Leezu's.

Through social media posts, podcasts, or bestselling books that help understand the human anatomy better, these women content creators are disseminating information on everything from sexual health and wellness to menstruation, abortion and contraception in a fun and easy-to-understand format.

"I have been passionate about spreading awareness on cervical cancer prevention on my social media. There has been more visibility to the issue in the last couple of years and now the aim is to get it to be a part of the national immunisation protocol," shares Dr Narendra.

Besides these sex-ed content creators, there are others like sex-focused psychotherapist Neha Bhat (who goes by the handle @indiansextherapist on social media), who through her unique educational and professional journey, is helping people break free from the shackles of shame, empowering them to embark on a journey of self-discovery.

"In an emotionally and sexually repressive postcolonial Indian society, sex therapy is often conflated with anything from advice-oriented sexology and sex education to sex work. I don't believe it to be people's fault that they do not understand what sex therapy really is but it's far from sleazy," she says.

An extension of her work, Bhat's book *Unashamed*, which was published recently, addresses the challenges of navigating life in a shapeshifting society like modern-day India. Since we are a society that values interpersonal relationships, she has explained why concepts like sex positivity, intergenerational trauma and mental health require innovative solutions tailormade for us.

"With easier access to being heard and seen through social media platforms, I see people wanting to come out of the shadows in large ways. Amongst the younger generation, there seems to be an urgent desire for authentic information about trauma, sexual health and mental health. With the older generation, where there is a little more hesitance, there is also a recognition that such conversations cannot be shied away from, forever," she says. ■

–Geetika Sachdev

become impure. To me, I try and unpick these stories, especially regarding women's identity in society. It's a gendered narrative told through the story—a subliminal strain of the woman always being the sacrificer who never stands up for herself. I am tired of those stories.

Q. Did you face much pushback when you first shared your views on social media?
I did. There was a certain kind of pushback from my family too. My husband was not thrilled with my work and so many of my friends became distant, but I have always had the support of my children. I believe the titillation threshold of people is very low—just a mere mention of the word 'sex' is enough to get them all worked up. It's a preconceived notion that if she's talking about it, there's something wrong with her. The idea that a woman can be independent is just too frightening for a lot of people.

Q. You also create content in Hindi to reach more people. Has it helped?
When I do a reel in Hindi, I get trolled a lot more. The kind of abuse I get is terrible. I admit it isn't easy for me to make this content because I still think in English. Despite the negativity, there have been so many heartwarming experiences that make it worthwhile. The last time I was in India two years ago, the person checking my passport at the airport told me he and his wife followed my content and praised my work.

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Q. What's next?
I am working on a book where we answer a lot of questions that come up in relationships. Sometimes, there are situations where women believe they are sabotaging their relationships even if they aren't being treated right. Our campaign against pleasure has been so deep that people like us who are pro pleasure have to break down the conditioning. ■

–with Geetika Sachdev